

Fight fire with fire

When I was in college, a curious phenomenon seemed to sweep the country. Teenagers were huddling around in groups, on street corners, poring over their newly acquired semi-smartphones snickering, laughing and talking in hushed undertones. What were they looking at? Mostly grainy videos or images that were surreptitiously taken. All of which were a gross violation of someone's privacy. This was the rise of the MMS phenomenon, and also the beginning of digital voyeurism in India.

Not much has changed since then – yes, those feature phones became smartphones, grainy images became crystal clear, but the basic human nature of wanting to snoop and access someone else's private content hasn't. Despite so much smut being available publicly, many are still drawn to voyeurism and get a thrill out of catching real people like themselves with their pants down; quite literally.

Think of the times you've snickered at some poor sod whose "hidden camera" footage you happened to chance upon in one of the many shady WhatsApp groups you find yourself being a member of these days. Somehow, you feel justified watching it. You say to yourself "if this guy/girl was stupid enough to not secure their private content, they deserved what was coming."

The funny thing though is that often, it's not with any malice that this media finds its way to the web and into your pockets. It's not always the result of a jilted lover seeking revenge that such things leak; it's more often just plain old carelessness. People seem to have an almost irrational level of trust in systems such as passwords or "the cloud". This was so evident recently when the whole world went into a voyeuristic tizzy during 'The Fap-pening' incident in which hackers got hold of compromising pictures of celebrities from their iCloud accounts.

As surprising as it may sound even regular people have, for the lack of a better phrase, self created naughty content on their phones. Who amongst us hasn't either clicked, sent or received a slightly raunchy selfie at some point in their lives? It's just a bit of innocent fun. But those with the right tools and know-how

can easily extract this data from your phone, discarded pen drive and even email accounts.

A voyeur today is no longer the smelly creep with binoculars trained on your bedroom window. Spying and digital voyeurism now has reached new heights, thanks to technology. Even regular cameras today are the size that would once have only been seen in spy movies – so you can only imagine the kind of technological wizardry the CIA wields. In the non-commercial space, you have nano drones the size of common insects that can not just record audio and video, but also apparently collect DNA samples with a pin prick. Ouch. Talk about violations! How long do you think it will take for black market or consumer variants of these devices to become commonplace?

Now, I'm not saying you board up your windows and sit indoors wearing a tin foil hat, but you can certainly ensure your private moments stay private. How do you do that? By learning the tricks of the spy trade. Only when you know the techniques employed by these creeps and what their gadgets are capable of, can you properly safeguard yourself. Fight fire with fire, essentially.

This is where our three-part cover story this month comes into the picture. It's not your regular run-of-the-mill NSA-level (and therefore lofty) spying story. We're talking about real world things like gadgets that are (shockingly) freely available here in India. You can just order them online! We're talking about software tools that any person with a limited knowledge of computer systems can use to breach your privacy. And of course, we're talking about all the counter-measures you can take to construct a metaphorical digital fortress around your data. So write in to us, tell us if our story helped you in any way but more importantly tell us any tricks you may have up your sleeve. For science. 



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"Only when you know the techniques employed by these creeps and what their gadgets are capable of, can you properly safeguard yourself"

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Siddharth Parwatay'.

Got feedback about this column?
Drop me a line at:
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